



THE MONKEY WHO SAVES

Narrated by Momo

A MonkeyMoney Collection



CHAPTER 1

The Day Momo Discovered the Secret

My name is Momo. Yeah, the monkey with the headphones, the yellow backpack, and the sneakers that never get dirty (well, almost never). But before all of this existed — the app, the games, the gold coins I collect in my hand every time I earn something — I was just an ordinary monkey with a very common problem: my money ran out before the month did.

It wasn't that I earned too little. It's that every coin that landed in my pocket already had somewhere to go: a craving, a new game, something shiny I saw in a shop window. Saving sounded like a boring word to me — one of those words adults use when they want to ruin your fun.

Everything changed one afternoon when my grandfather — an old monkey, the kind who's seen it all — showed me a pink ceramic piggy bank, just like the one I carry with me everywhere today. It was full to the brim.

“How much do you think is in there?” he asked me.

I threw out a random number, the way you'd guess how many candies are in a jar. I was way off. What was inside wasn't just the money he had saved. It was something more: money that the money itself had produced.

That's where I heard, for the first time, the two words that are now at the center of everything I do: **compound interest**.

My grandfather didn't give me an economics lesson. He told me a story. He told me about a king, a chessboard, and a grain of rice that doubled on every square until it became a mountain no kingdom could ever pay. He told me how money, when you let it grow, doesn't grow in a straight line: it

grows like a snowball rolling downhill, bigger and faster with every turn.

That afternoon I didn't understand all the math. But I understood something more important: there was a secret, and most people went through life never knowing it.

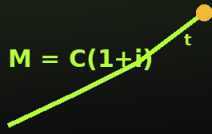
From that day on, I started asking myself questions. Why could saving one coin today turn, over time, into so much more than one coin? Why was time — the very thing I used to waste without a second thought — actually the most valuable ingredient of all?

This book is the result of those questions. I'm not going to tell it to you like a teacher standing at a chalkboard. I'm going to tell it to you the way I lived it: with mistakes, with surprises, with moments when I wanted to spend it all and didn't (and others when I did, and regretted it).

If you also feel like money slips through your fingers, stick around. Let's open that piggy bank together.

CHAPTER 2

What I Learned About Compound Interest


$$M = C(1+i)^t$$

After that afternoon with my grandfather, I didn't leave him alone. I asked him over and over how it was possible for money to “make more money” without him lifting a finger. Eventually, he sat down with me with a pencil and a napkin, and explained it like this:

“Imagine you put 100 coins in the bank, and the bank pays you 10% a year. At the end of the first year, you don't just have your 100 coins — you have 10 more coins, earned out of nowhere. Now you have 110.”

Simple enough so far. That's simple interest: you always earn on the same base.

“But here's the trick,” he went on. “The next year, the bank doesn't give you 10% of your original 100 coins. It gives you 10% of the 110 you already have. In other words, you earn interest... on the interest you already earned.”

That blew my mind. Money didn't grow the same amount every year. It grew faster and faster, because each gain got added to the base the next one was calculated on.

The formula my grandfather drew on the napkin looked like this:

Final amount = Initial capital × (1 + interest rate) ^ number of years

At first those symbols looked like hieroglyphics to me. But once I started plugging in numbers, something clicked. With 100 coins at 10% a year:

- Year 1: 110 - Year 2: 121 - Year 3: 133 - Year 10: 259 - Year 20: 673 - Year 30: 1,745

Look at the jump between year 20 and year 30. It's not double. It's almost triple. That's what they call "exponential growth," and it's the difference between saving like someone filling a bucket with a cup, and saving like someone who opens a faucet that never turns off.

That's when I understood why my grandfather kept insisting on one thing: it's not just about how much you save. It's about how much time you let those savings work for you.



CHAPTER 3

The Rule of 72 (My Favorite Trick)

Over time I learned a shortcut I use every day, even now that I know how to do the full math. It's called the **rule of 72**, and it's so simple it almost feels like cheating.

Here's how it works: you divide 72 by the annual interest rate, and the result tells you, roughly, how many years it takes for your money to **double**.

- At 6% a year: $72 \div 6 = 12$ years to double your money. - At 9% a year: $72 \div 9 = 8$ years. - At 12% a year: $72 \div 12 = 6$ years.

The first time I did this math with my own savings, I felt something strange: excitement over a number. That had never happened to me before. I realized that if I kept my money at a reasonable rate, in about 10 years I'd see it doubled without adding a single extra coin.

That trick changed how I saw every spending decision. I stopped thinking, "Can I afford this?" and started thinking, "How many years would it have taken this money to double if I'd let it grow instead?"

I didn't always choose wisely. But at least, from then on, I chose with my eyes open.



CHAPTER 4

When I Started Saving Early

I have a friend, Toro, who started saving ten years later than I did. When I told him, he laughed: “Ten years isn't that much, Momo, I'll catch up.”

He didn't catch up. And that's one of the most important lessons in this whole book.

Let's say I start at age 20, save 100 coins a month for only 10 years (until I'm 30), and after that I never contribute again. I let compound interest do its work alone, at 8% a year, until I turn 60.

Toro, on the other hand, waits until he's 30 to start. But he's disciplined: he saves 100 coins a month for 30 straight years, until he's 60, at the same 8% rate.

Toro put in three times more of his own money than I did. And still, by the time we both turn 60... I have more.

How is that possible? Because my money had 40 years to grow, and Toro's only had 30. Those first ten years of head start were worth more than twenty extra years of contributions.

When I understood this, I stopped believing the excuse “I'll save once I earn more.” Time doesn't wait for you to be ready. It starts working from the very first coin you save, not from the perfect coin you think you'll have someday.



CHAPTER 5

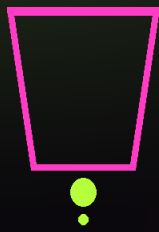
My First Savings Account

The first time I walked into a bank alone, with no one holding my hand, I felt like I was doing something grown-up. The teller asked me what kind of account I wanted, and I had no idea there were so many options.

I learned that not all saved money earns the same. A checking account, meant for everyday spending, barely pays any interest. A savings account pays a bit more, because the bank knows that money tends to sit still longer. And there are instruments like CDs (certificates of deposit), where you agree not to touch the money for a fixed period, and in exchange you get a better rate.

I also understood something nobody had ever explained to me: there's a difference between the **nominal rate** (the one the bank advertises on the sign) and the **effective rate** (the one that actually ends up in your pocket, after interest compounds several times a year). Two banks can both advertise “10% annual” and give you different results, depending on whether that interest is calculated monthly, quarterly, or yearly.

From then on, before putting my money anywhere, I always ask the same question: “How often does this interest compound?” That one question, by itself, has saved me from more than one bad deal.



CHAPTER 6

The Invisible Thief That Almost Ruined Me

For a while I felt proud: my savings were tucked away, growing every month, everything was going well. Until one day I went to buy something that had cost a lot less just months earlier, and the same amount of money didn't stretch as far anymore.

That's where I met my true enemy: **inflation**.

My grandfather explained it with an image I've never forgotten: "Imagine your money is water stored in a bucket, and inflation is a tiny hole in the bottom. You don't see it dripping, but over time, the bucket empties out just the same."

If my money grew at 5% a year, but prices rose at 4% a year, I was really only gaining 1% in actual purchasing power. And if inflation ever outpaced the rate I was being paid, my money "grew" in number, but lost value in real life.

That was the first time I understood that saving without thinking about inflation is like filling a leaky bucket: you can keep pouring water in your whole life and never quite fill it up.

That discovery was what pushed me to take the next step.



CHAPTER 7

The Day I Stopped Just Saving

Saving had taught me discipline. But I realized that to truly beat inflation and make my money grow with real force, I had to take one more step: **investing**.

I'm not talking about anything risky or complicated. I'm talking about simple instruments, designed for someone just starting out: mutual funds, bonds, higher-rate CDs, and eventually, a first timid look at stocks.

The difference between saving and investing is subtle but huge. Saving means keeping money safe, with almost no risk, but modest growth. Investing means putting that money to work in something that can grow more, in exchange for accepting some uncertainty.

My grandfather gave me a rule I still follow today: "First build your safety cushion by saving. Only once that cushion exists should you start investing what's left over." I never invested the money I needed for an emergency. That always stayed in my piggy bank, safe and available.

Taking that first step into investing was like shifting compound interest into second gear: my money no longer grew just from bank interest, but from the returns of assets that generated value on their own.



CHAPTER 8

The Traps of My Own Mind

If there's one thing I learned along the way, it's that the biggest obstacle to saving was never the money. It was me.

I discovered that my brain is wired to prefer a small reward today over a bigger reward tomorrow. Scientists call it “present bias,” but to me it just felt like an urgent craving every time I saw something shiny in a store window.

I also fell into the trap of comparing my savings to the spending of other monkeys around me. I'd see someone with something new, and feel like I also “deserved” to spend, even when I didn't need to.

What helped me most was one simple change: instead of relying on willpower (which failed me often), I built automatic habits. I set things up so that the moment money came in, part of it went straight into savings, before my hands could even touch it. I realized I wasn't saving whatever was left over at the end of the month — I was saving first, and living on what remained.

That small change in order changed everything.



CHAPTER 9

Stories I Heard Along the Way

Along this journey I heard stories that stuck with me, both good and bad.

I met an older monkey who, since she was young, saved a small part of every paycheck, without exception, for 40 years straight. She never earned a huge salary. But by the time she reached old age, compound interest had done its quiet, unstoppable work: her modest savings had become a nest egg that let her live comfortably.

I also heard the opposite story: entire countries that, after losing control of prices, went through hyperinflations where money lost value from one day to the next. A lifetime of savings evaporated in months — not because people hadn't saved, but because the ground they were saving on collapsed beneath them.

And I heard stories of debt: monkeys who ended up with compound interest working against them, letting a credit card balance grow unpaid, watching that debt multiply with the very same quiet force I had used in my favor.

That's when I understood something I hadn't seen so clearly before: compound interest isn't good or bad. It's a force. And like any force, it can build or destroy, depending on which side you're standing on.



CHAPTER 10

The Mistakes That Almost Cost Me Everything

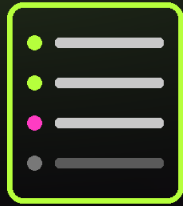
Not everything in my story was perfect discipline. I had stumbles that nearly ruined years of effort.

The first: pulling my savings out too early. I once broke a CD halfway through on a whim, and lost not just the interest I'd earned, but the chance for that money to keep compounding. I learned that interrupting compound interest halfway through is like cutting down a tree right before it gives its best fruit.

The second: using a credit card without understanding that compound interest works there too — just against me. A small debt I didn't pay off on time grew month after month, until it became a real problem. It was the hardest lesson: the same formula that grows your savings can grow a debt, just as fast.

The third: leaving my “savings” sitting there without ever checking the rate I was being paid, while inflation quietly ate away at it. It's not enough to just put money aside — you have to make sure that money is actually working for you.

Each one of those mistakes hurt. But each one also taught me more than any textbook ever could.



CHAPTER 11

How I Built My Plan (and How You Can Build Yours)

After so many stumbles and wins, I put together a simple plan that I still follow today. I'll share it with you exactly as I use it:

Step 1: Define your safety cushion. Before investing, set aside an emergency fund — always available, with no risk.

Step 2: Automate your savings. Set aside part of every payment the moment it arrives, before you spend anything.

Step 3: Choose where your money grows. Compare effective rates, not just nominal ones, and understand how often the interest compounds.

Step 4: Give it time. Don't pull your savings out early. Let compound interest do its quiet work.

Step 5: Check in, but don't touch. Review your rates and your plan periodically, but resist the urge to move your money on impulse.

Step 6: Once you have your cushion, take the leap into investing what's left over, using instruments you genuinely understand.

This plan isn't complicated. But it works because it's consistent. And as you learned in Chapter 2: compound interest doesn't reward whoever saves the fastest — it rewards whoever saves the longest.



CHAPTER 12

A Letter From Momo to You

If you've made it this far, you already know the secret my grandfather showed me that afternoon with the pink piggy bank.

I won't lie to you: saving isn't always exciting. It doesn't feel like winning a game or opening a present. Most days, it feels like a small, quiet decision: putting away instead of spending, waiting instead of rushing.

But now you know what I didn't know at your age: those small decisions, repeated over time, turn into something enormous. Compound interest doesn't need you to be rich to get started. It just needs you to start, and to give it time.

I started with a pink piggy bank and a story about a chessboard. You can start today, with whatever you have in your pocket right now.

I'm not asking you to be perfect. I wasn't either: I broke a CD too early, let a debt grow that I shouldn't have, spent when I should have saved. But every stumble taught me something no book could have taught me on its own.

So here's my last question, the same one my grandfather asked me: how much do you think you could have, if you started today and gave your own piggy bank enough time?

Open it. Start. I'll be right here, counting coins with you.

— *Momo*